

Untangling Complex Sentences — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: 15 min

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — BREAKING A SENTENCE INTO CHUNKS

THE PROBLEM

Long sentences feel confusing because your brain tries to hold the whole thing in your head at once. The fix is to stop reading it as one block, and instead break it into its **main point** and its **extra information**.

THE TECHNIQUE — 4 STEPS

1. Find the **main clause** — the core "who did what" of the sentence. It should make sense completely on its own.
2. Find any **subordinate clauses** — extra chunks giving more detail, usually set off by commas or a connective word
3. Mentally cross out the extra chunks and re-read just the main clause — check you now understand the core meaning
4. Add each extra chunk back in one at a time, asking what detail it adds (when, why, despite what, describing whom)

Connective words that often signal a subordinate clause is starting: although, despite, because, since, while, whereas, having, which, who, that, even though, in spite of

2 · WORKED EXAMPLE

Sofia refused to leave the library, *even though the caretaker had already switched off half the lights and was jangling his keys pointedly by the door*, **because she was one page from finishing the story**.

STEP 1 Main clause: "Sofia refused to leave the library" — makes sense alone.

STEP 2 Two extra chunks: one starting "even though" (a contrast — someone wants her to leave), one starting "because" (her reason for staying).

STEP 4 Full meaning: Sofia is being pressured to leave (dimming lights, jangling keys) but stays anyway, for a specific reason — she's nearly finished her book.

3 · PRACTICE

1. "Although the coach had warned them twice about the tide times, having checked her own watch only minutes before, Priya still lost track of how long they had been exploring the rock pools."
Identify the main clause of this sentence.

2. Using the same sentence above, what does the "although... twice" chunk add to our understanding of what happens?

3. *"The letter, which had clearly been rewritten several times given the crossed-out lines beneath the final version, still ended with the same uncertain question it always had."*

Break this sentence into its main clause and its extra chunk. What is the extra chunk telling us?

Despite having lived three streets away from the old cinema his entire life, and despite walking past its boarded-up entrance most mornings on his way to school, Marcus had never actually known anyone who remembered what film had been playing the night it finally closed for good.

4. Break the passage sentence above into its main clause and its extra chunks. What is the sentence's actual core point, once the extra detail is removed?

5. Why might the writer have chosen to put so much detail before the main clause, instead of stating the main point first?

Apply this every time: If a sentence feels confusing, don't reread it the same way twice. Find the main clause first, understand that alone, then add the extra chunks back in one at a time.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

1. **Q1:** "Priya still lost track of how long they had been exploring the rock pools."
2. **Q2:** Adds irony/tension — she had been warned and had even checked the time herself, making her losing track more surprising or careless, not a simple accident.
3. **Q3:** Main clause: "The letter still ended with the same uncertain question it always had." Extra chunk ("which had clearly been rewritten...") tells us the writer struggled with or reworked the letter multiple times, even though the ending stayed the same — suggesting the difficulty was elsewhere in the letter, not the final question.
4. **Q4:** Main clause: "Marcus had never actually known anyone who remembered what film had been playing the night it finally closed." Core point: despite living nearby and passing it daily, this specific piece of local history was unknown to him.
5. **Q5:** Accept reasonable answers — e.g. builds irony/expectation (we expect him to know, given the proximity) before revealing he doesn't, making the final point land harder.